PERKALATE FOR BRANDS

Launch a loyalty program in a day, without building an app

A practical guide for owners of shops, studios, salons and local brands. From Perkalate.

Why most small brands never launch one

Ask almost any owner whether they want a loyalty program and they'll say yes. Ask why they don't have one yet and you'll hear the same three answers.

"We'd need an app." Building a branded app costs real money, takes months, and then you have to convince customers to download one more thing.

"We'd need new hardware." Punch-card tablets, new POS add-ons, a QR stand at the counter. Every piece is another thing to buy, set up and keep working.

"We don't have time to run it." Points rules, tiers, emails, redemption tracking. It sounds like a part-time job.

Here's the thing: none of that is what makes loyalty work. A loyalty program is really just three things.

1. **A reason to come back.** A reward that's worth something.
2. **The right people.** Rewards that reach customers who'll actually use them.
3. **A way to redeem.** Something easy at checkout, so the reward turns into a visit.

If you can do those three things, you have a loyalty program. You can do all three in a day.

Step 1 (morning): Decide what you want more of

Before you think about rewards, pick one outcome. Just one. The most common ones we see:

- **More first visits** from people who already shop your category but haven't found you.
- **More second visits.** A lot of first-time customers never come back, and the second visit is where habits start.
- **More visits in a slow window,** like weekday mornings at a studio or the post-holiday lull at a boutique.
- **Bigger baskets** from customers who already love you.

Write it down as a sentence: "I want 30 more second visits from new customers this month." That sentence will make every other decision easy.

Step 2 (late morning): Pick your audience

This is where most loyalty programs go wrong. A punch card rewards whoever happens to walk in. A discount blast goes to everyone on your list, including people who would have come in anyway.

A better approach is to target people by what they actually do. On Perkalate, members connect the loyalty accounts they already have and choose what they share. That gives you permissioned, verified signals to build an audience from, like:

- **Category:** people who already shop in your category (beauty, fitness, apparel, home, food and drink).
- **Loyalty behavior:** members in a top tier with another program, or with points about to expire.
- **Moments:** birthday this month.
- **Frequency:** people who visit businesses like yours often.
- **Location:** people who live or spend near your store.

You never see individuals, only audience totals. Members stay in control of their data, and you still get precise targeting.

Tip: start narrow. "Verified locals who already spend on Pilates and have a birthday this month" beats "everyone in Scottsdale." A smaller, sharper audience usually gets more of your reward budget redeemed by people who matter.

Step 3 (lunch): Design one reward

Keep it simple. One audience, one reward. Some good starting points:

Goal	Reward idea
First visits	A first-visit reward, like a free class, a free add-on service, or $15 off a first purchase
Second visits	A thank-you reward that unlocks after the first visit
Slow windows	Bonus value for a specific day or time
Birthdays	A birthday-month treat
Bigger baskets	A gift with purchase over a set amount

Three rules make a reward work:

1. **It has to be worth showing up for.** A tiny discount nobody notices doesn't change behavior.

2. **It should be easy to understand in one line.** "20% off in your birthday month" works. A rules paragraph doesn't.
3. **It should have a limit.** One use per member and a clear end date keep your budget predictable.

With Perkalate, you only pay for the rewards you fund. You set the budget, so you're in control of how much you spend.

Step 4 (afternoon): Set up redemption at checkout

This is the part owners worry about most, and it's the easiest.

On Perkalate there's no app to build and no new hardware. Members save your reward as a Pass in the Perkalate app. At checkout they show the Pass, and you apply the reward at the register you already use. Online, it works as a code.

Before you launch, do a two-minute walkthrough with whoever runs your counter:

- What the Pass looks like.
- What the reward is and any limits (one per member, end date).
- Where to see redemptions in your dashboard.

That's your staff training.

Step 5 (end of day): Launch and watch

Launch the reward to your audience. Members who match see it in their Perkalate wallet, right alongside offers from programs like Amex, Delta and Marriott. That's a big part of why rewards get seen: they show up where people already look for value, not buried in an inbox.

For the first two weeks, watch three numbers in your dashboard:

1. **Viewed:** how many matched members saw your reward.
2. **Claimed:** how many saved it.
3. **Redeemed:** how many actually came in and used it.

If lots of people view it but few claim, make the reward more compelling. If people claim but don't redeem, make it easier to use (a longer window, or valid at more times). If it works, keep it running and add a second reward for a second goal.

What "a loyalty program" looks like after 30 days

You don't need tiers and points tables on day one. After a month, a simple program on Perkalate usually looks like this:

- **A welcome reward** for verified new customers in your category.
- **A thank-you reward** that brings first-timers back for visit two.
- **A birthday reward** for regulars.

Three rewards, each aimed at a specific group, each measured. That's a real loyalty program, and you built it without an app, without hardware, and without a big upfront cost.

Quick checklist

☐ One goal, written as a sentence
☐ One audience, narrow and specific
☐ One reward, explained in a single line, with a limit
☐ Budget set (you only pay for the rewards you fund)
☐ Counter team walked through the Pass
☐ Launched, with a reminder to check Viewed / Claimed / Redeemed in two weeks

Get started

Perkalate is free to start, and you only pay for the rewards you fund. 100+ brands are already on it.

If you already have a loyalty program, Perkalate puts it in front of verified customers who don't know you yet, right next to Amex, Delta and Marriott. If you don't, it's the easiest way to start one.

Get early access at perkalate.com/brands.

Amex, Delta and Marriott are programs Perkalate members can connect. Perkalate is not affiliated with them.